



◀ RAMBHUAL NISHAD, *64*

| SP | *Sultanpur, UP*

Maneka Gandhi's candidacy emerged unscathed from the fog of suspense swirling out from son Varun's status but the eight-time MP still ended up registering her first electoral loss since 1991. Her nemesis? A hardcase choppered in from Gorakhpur, a two-term MLA/ex-minister with both BJP and BSP on his resume, besides some prize Wild East action.



◀ KALICHARAN MUNDA, *62*

| CONGRESS | *Khunti (ST), Jharkhand*

It was one Munda against another, but remarkably, the victorious one was coming back after a 24-year hiatus, like an old gunslinger returning to prove he was still the quickest draw. Kalicharan Munda has been MLA twice but between 1992-2000—the prehistory of Jharkhand, so to speak, because it was spun off as a separate state only in November 2000. The man he defeated, Arjun Munda, had in the meantime gone on to be the new state's second CM, serving 70 months over three stints, as well as Union minister twice.

ROOP KUMARI CHAUDHRY, *47* ▶

| BJP | *Mahasamund, Chhattisgarh*

A member of the Aghariya Patel community, the former MLA and parliamentary secretary to the Chhattisgarh government redeemed the trust the party reposed in her by fielding her against former state home minister Tamradhwaj Sahu—that too in a seat with a substantial Sahu vote.



▼ UTKARSH VERMA 'MADHUR', *38*

| SP | *Kheri, UP*

The BJP could not find it expedient to defrock Ajay Mishra Teni, Union MoS Home, despite a case that made angry farmers much angrier. So it fell upon this young Kurmi leader, a Lakhimpur Kheri native who showed early promise by winning his debut MLA election at age 25, to do the honours.



JOYANTA BASUMATARY, *48*

| UNITED PEOPLES PARTY LIBERAL | *Kokrajhar (ST), Assam*



The UPPL's birth in 2015, out of the union of two older parties, had signified the heating up of competition within the Bodo political space. Basumatary is a face of its verve, having defeated Bodoland People's Front veteran Chandan Brahma for his 2021 assembly debut. Now he has trounced BPF No. 2 Kampa Borgoyari to enter the Lok Sabha.

RICHARD VANLALHMANGAIHA, *46*

| ZORAM PEOPLE'S MOVEMENT | *Mizoram (ST)*



This is the first time the ZPM, the ruling party in Mizoram, has won the state's only Lok Sabha seat since its 2017 birth. Its recent ascendancy perhaps made it a logical outcome, but the way this commerce graduate defeated K. Vanlalvena, a Rajya Sabha MP and Mizo National Front stalwart with 42 per cent votes, puts a seal on it.

–Anilesh S. Mahajan, Jeemon Jacob, Prashant Srivastava, Amitabh Srivastava, Rohit Parihar, Dhaval S. Kulkarni, Rahul Noronha and Kaushik Deka